

IN CONTEXT

A climate of treason

In 1570, Pope Pius V excommunicated Elizabeth I, releasing her Catholic subjects from allegiance to her. This sparked plots against her life, among them the Ridolfi Plot (1571) and the Babington Plot (1586). In response, Elizabeth employed secret agents to help unearth possible conspirators, at home and abroad. These activities were supervised by her “spymaster,” Francis Walsingham, and secretary of state, Robert Cecil. It was to Cecil that Dowland wrote when, following an incident in Italy, he became fearful that he would be accused of treason.



ROBERT CECIL, 1ST EARL OF
SALISBURY

Nothing is known for certain about John Dowland’s early days.